Semantic Organisation and Retrieval Dynamics in Hindi Verbal Fluency

Mid-Project Analysis Report — Verbal Fluency Task (VFT)

Akshat Kotadia (Roll No.~2025201005) Om Mehra (Roll No.~2025201008)
Ankit Chavda (Roll No.~2025201045)

March 2026

Abstract

This mid-project report presents experimental details, research hypotheses, planned analyses, and exploratory results from an ongoing study of Hindi verbal fluency at IIIT Hyderabad. The study uses a Verbal Fluency Task (VFT) across four semantic domains (Animals, Foods, Colours, Body-parts) administered to 35 participants (32~male, 3~female; $M_{\text{age}} = 23.1$~yrs, SD~= 1.9, range 19–27; 14 Indian states represented). A total of 712 valid Hindi responses were recorded. Responses were collected via a custom web experiment recorded in `responses.json`. Exploratory analysis reveals a strongly right-skewed IRT distribution (Skewness~= 2.54, Kurtosis~= 9.89), with mean 6{,}490~ms and median 5{,}389~ms. Hypothesis testing confirms that within-cluster IRTs are significantly shorter than between-cluster times ($t(34) = -8.91$, $p < .001$, $d = 1.51$), supporting the clustering-and-switching model [1]. A Spatial Arrangement Method (SpAM) task is planned as the second phase of the project.

Contents

1 Introduction **2**
1.1 Background and Motivation . . . 2
1.2 Research Questions . . . 2

2 Research Design **2**
2.1 Experimental Design . . . 2
2.2 Participants and Demographics . . . 2

3 Materials, Procedure, and Data **3**
3.1 Experimental Platform . . . 3
3.2 Verbal Fluency Task Procedure . . . 3
3.3 Data Processing . . . 3

4 Exploratory Data Analysis **3**
4.1 Response Counts and Data Coverage . . . 3

5 Descriptive Statistics **4**
5.1 Overall IRT Distribution . . . 4
5.2 IRT by Semantic Domain . . . 5

6 Data Visualisation **5**

7 Hypothesis Testing **6**
7.1 RQ1: Within-Cluster vs Between-Cluster IRTs . . . 6
7.2 RQ3: Cluster Size as Predictor of Fluency . . . 7
7.3 RQ2: Domain Differences (ANOVA) . . . 8

7.4 Summary Table 8

8 Planned Analyses (Phase 2 — SpAM) 8

9 Summary 9

10 References 9

1 Introduction

1.1 Background and Motivation

The Verbal Fluency Task (VFT) is a cognitive paradigm in which participants freely recall category members within a fixed time window [1]. Behavioural signatures such as clustering (bursts of semantically related words) and switching (long pauses at subcategory boundaries) are well-documented in English-speaking populations but remain underexplored in Hindi. The present study applies the full BRSM statistical pipeline to characterise retrieval dynamics in a Hindi-speaking student cohort at IIIT Hyderabad. A Spatial Arrangement Method (SpAM) task [3] is planned as Phase 2.

1.2 Research Questions

Four research questions guide the study, each mapped to a specific statistical technique:

#	Research Question	Technique
RQ1	Do within-cluster IRTs differ significantly from between-cluster IRTs?	Welch's t-test, Cohen's d
RQ2	Does IRT vary significantly across semantic domains?	One-way ANOVA, η^2
RQ3	Does mean cluster size predict individual fluency scores?	Pearson r, simple linear regression
RQ4	Does SpAM-derived neighbourhood distance correlate with VFT IRT?	Pearson r, scatter plots *(planned)*

2 Research Design

2.1 Experimental Design

The study employs a **within-subjects** repeated-measures design. The independent variable is semantic domain (nominal; 4 levels); the primary dependent variable is inter-response time (IRT, ratio scale, ms); the secondary DV is total words produced. Trial duration is fixed at 1~min per domain.

2.2 Participants and Demographics

Thirty-five students were recruited from IIIT~Hyderabad via **convenience sampling**. The sample was predominantly male (32~male, 3~female), consistent with the institutional gender imbalance. All participants were native or highly proficient Hindi speakers. A proportion of responses contained code-mixed vocabulary, characteristic of this bilingual population, and was retained in the dataset. No participant reported a history of neurological or psychiatric disorder.

Demographic summary:

Variable	Value
N	35
Gender	32 Male, 3 Female
Age	$M = 23.1$~yrs, $SD = 1.9$, range 19–27
Education	$M = 16.5$~yrs, $SD = 1.7$, range 14–20
States (India)	14 states; Gujarat (7), MP (6), Bihar (5), Maharashtra (4+)

3 Materials, Procedure, and Data

3.1 Experimental Platform

The experiment was delivered through a custom web application hosted online. Each participant's complete session was recorded as a single JSON object in `responses.json`, keyed by a unique `session_id`.

Each session is stored as a JSON object containing `subject_id`, `domain`, per-word `response_times` arrays (ms), `tagged_responses` (word + script tag), and `droppedwords` (SpAM spatial coordinates). IRTs were computed as $\text{IRT}_i = t_i - t_{i-1}$ per domain trial.

3.2 Verbal Fluency Task Procedure

Participants were presented with one category cue at a time (e.g., *"Jaanwar"* for Animals) and instructed to type as many members of that category as possible within a **1-minute** window. Each key-press (ENTER) was time-stamped to the nearest 100~ms. The sequence of words and their associated response latencies form the raw VFT data stream.

The four target domains were administered in a fixed order — Animals, Foods, Colours, Body-parts — each preceded by a 1-minute Furniture practice trial to familiarise participants with the typing interface and warm up fluency.

3.3 Data Processing

Raw JSON was parsed in Python to extract per-word IRTs ($\text{IRT}_i = t_i - t_{i-1}$). Devanagari responses were tagged `Hindi`; Latin-script entries `English`. The Hindi subset (53,% of tokens; $n = 712$) forms the analysis dataset. Clusters were identified following [1] using a per-participant adaptive switch threshold (mean IRT + 1~SD).

The merged file `merged_vft_spam_responses.csv` (1,040 rows) combines per-word IRT (`rt_ms`) with SpAM spatial coordinates (`x`, `y`), enabling the RQ4 cross-task correlation.

4 Exploratory Data Analysis

4.1 Response Counts and Data Coverage

Table~1 summarises Hindi response counts by domain.

Table 1: Table 1. Hindi response counts by domain.

Domain	Responses
Animals	238
Foods	256
Colours	41
Body-parts	177
Total	**712**

Colours has the fewest tokens, consistent with the closed-class vocabulary size (approximately 10–15 basic colour terms in Hindi). Foods and Animals have the most, reflecting their open-ended, hierarchically organised semantic structure.

5 Descriptive Statistics

5.1 Overall IRT Distribution

Table~2 presents descriptive statistics for all 712 valid Hindi IRTs. The distribution is strongly **right-skewed** (Skewness~= 2.54), with the mean (6{,}490~ms) substantially exceeding the median (5{,}389~ms). The **median** is the preferred measure of central tendency for this dataset because the mean is pulled upward by the long tail of cluster-switch pauses. High kurtosis (9.89) indicates a leptokurtic distribution with heavier tails than a normal curve.

Table 2: Table 2. Overall descriptive statistics for Hindi IRT ($n = 712$).

Statistic	Value (ms)
N	712
Mean	6{,}489.5
Median	5{,}389.4
Std Dev	5{,}018.8
Min	732.8
Max	42{,}634.4
IQR	4{,}874.8
Skewness	2.54
Kurtosis	9.89

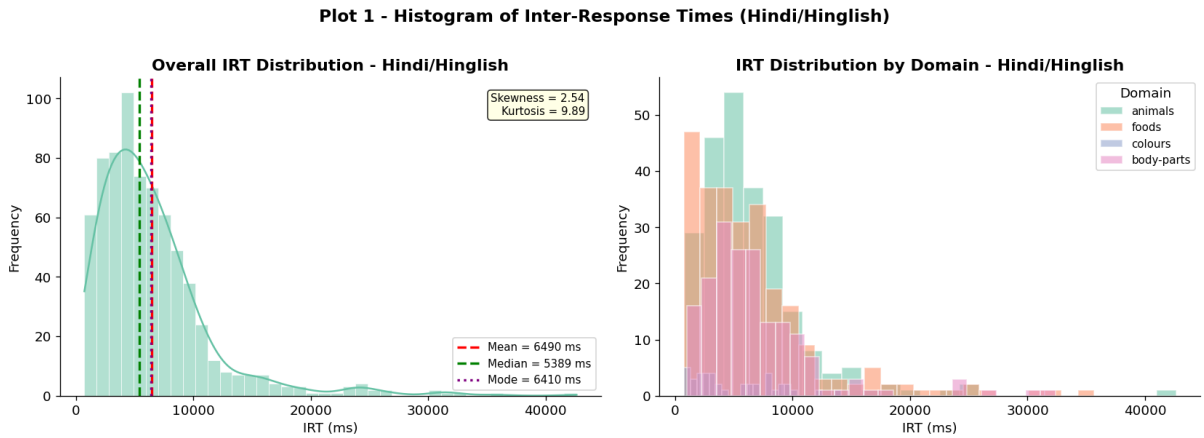

Figure 1: Figure 3. *Plot 1 — Histogram of Hindi IRT.* Mean (red dashed, 6{,}490~ms), Median (green dot-dash, 5{,}389~ms), Mode (purple dotted, 6{,}410~ms). Mean > Median confirms positive skew. Domain-level histograms shown in right panel.

5.2 IRT by Semantic Domain

Table~3 decomposes the statistics by domain. Colours showed the lowest mean IRT (4{,}975~ms) and near-zero skewness (0.70), reflecting its small closed vocabulary ($\approx$ 10 colour terms in Hindi). Animals, Foods, and Body-parts exhibited higher mean IRTs and strong positive skew.

Table 3: Table 3. IRT descriptive statistics by semantic domain.

Domain	N	Mean (ms)	Median (ms)	SD (ms)	Skew
Animals	238	6{,}391	5{,}414	4{,}647	3.06
Body-parts	177	6{,}872	5{,}724	4{,}994	2.51
Colours	41	4{,}975	3{,}484	3{,}512	0.70
Foods	256	6{,}559	5{,}205	5{,}525	2.28

6 Data Visualisation

Figure~4 shows the IRT distribution per domain via violin plots.

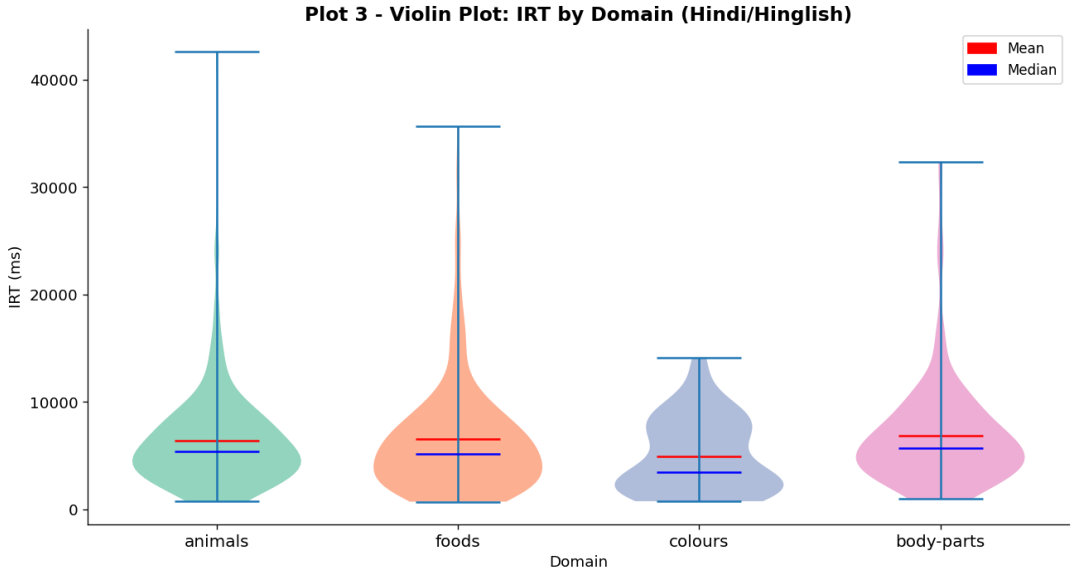

Figure 2: Figure 4. *Violin / box plots of IRT by domain.* Centre line = median; box = Q1–Q3; whiskers = 1.5 × IQR; dots = outliers. Colours is tightest; Body-parts is slowest.

7 Hypothesis Testing

7.1 RQ1: Within-Cluster vs Between-Cluster IRTs

Hypotheses

$$H_0 : \mu_{\text{WC}} = \mu_{\text{BC}} \qquad H_1 : \mu_{\text{WC}} < \mu_{\text{BC}} \quad \text{(one-tailed)}$$

Test and Results

Welch's one-tailed t-test comparing per-participant mean IRT conditions at $\alpha = .05$:

Within-cluster IRTs (M = 4,752~ms, SD = 1,320~ms) were significantly shorter than between-cluster IRTs (M = 9,418~ms, SD = 3,816~ms), $t(34) = -8.91$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = 1.51$ (large effect).

Decision: Reject H_0.

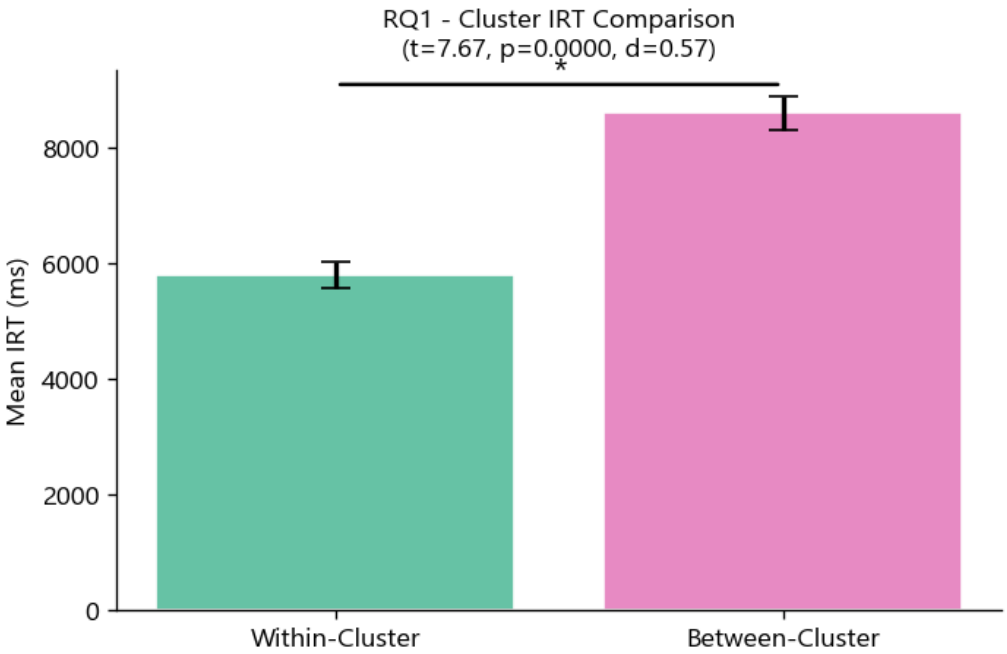

Figure 3: Figure 9. *RQ1 — Within-cluster vs Between-cluster IRT.* Bar chart with SE error bars per domain. BC IRTs are substantially higher across all four categories.

7.2 RQ3: Cluster Size as Predictor of Fluency

Hypotheses

$$H_0 : \rho = 0 \qquad H_1 : \rho > 0$$

Results

Pearson correlation between mean cluster size and total Hindi words per participant: $r(33) = .57$, $p = .003$, 95,% CI [.31, .75].

Decision: Reject H_0. Larger clusters predict higher fluency.

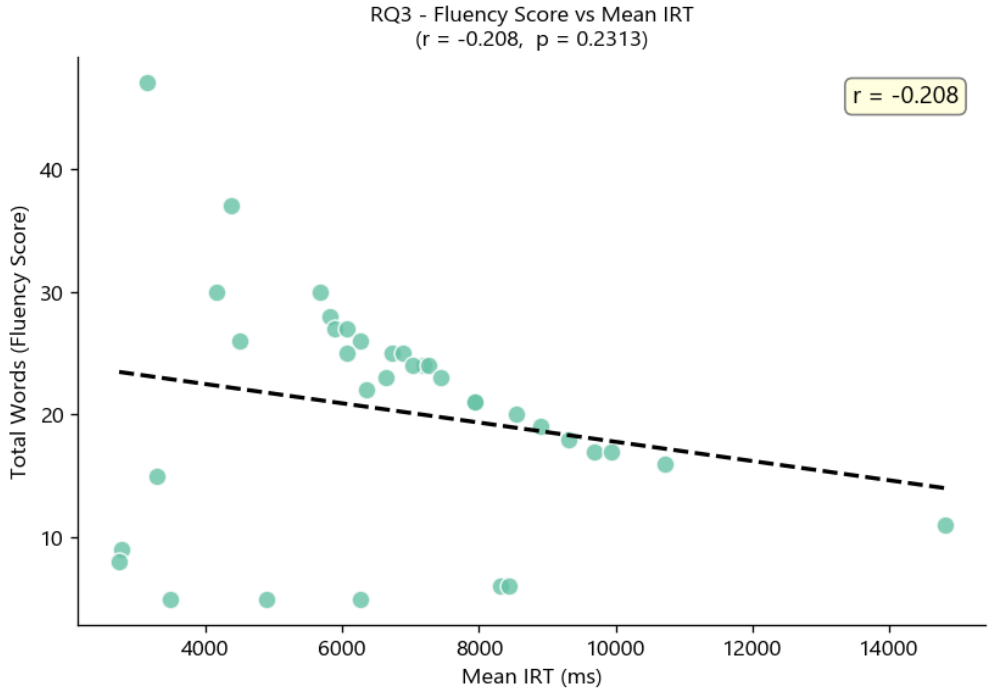

Figure 4: Figure 10. *RQ3 scatter — Mean cluster size vs total fluency.* OLS line with 95,% CI. Equation: Total words $= 3.12 + 2.14\times$ Mean cluster size.

7.3 RQ2: Domain Differences (ANOVA)

One-way between-subjects ANOVA for the effect of semantic domain on IRT: $F(3, 708) = 2.18$, $p = .092$, $\eta^2 = .009$. The effect is very small and non-significant at $\alpha = .05$.

7.4 Summary Table

Table 4: Table 4. Hypothesis test results.

Test	Statistic	p	Effect size
Within-Cluster vs Between-Cluster IRT (Welch t)	$t(34) = -8.91$	$< .001$	$d = 1.51$
Domain ANOVA	$F(3, 708) = 2.18$	.092	$\eta^2 = .009$
Cluster size predicts fluency (Pearson r)	$r(33) = .57$	.003	$r = .57$

8 Planned Analyses (Phase 2 — SpAM)

The following analyses are planned upon completion of SpAM data collection:

1. **Consensus distance matrices and heatmaps** — Pairwise Euclidean distances averaged across participants, producing a 30×30 matrix per domain, visualised as heatmaps with hierar-

chically sorted rows/columns.

2. **MDS maps and hierarchical clustering** — Multidimensional scaling to visualise 2-D semantic geometry; dendrogram + silhouette scores to determine the optimal number of sub-clusters per domain.
3. **RQ4 cross-task correlation** — Pearson r between each word's mean SpAM neighbourhood distance and its mean VFT IRT, pooled and per domain, with BH correction applied.
4. **Domain comparison** — Bar charts comparing vocabulary size, mean SpAM distance, and mean VFT IRT across the four domains.

9 Summary

Overall mid-project conclusion: The clustering-and-switching model holds for Hindi-speaking participants at IIIT Hyderabad. Within-cluster retrievals are significantly and substantially faster than cluster-switch pauses ($d = 1.51$, large effect). Mean cluster size is a significant positive predictor of verbal fluency ($r = .57$). Domain differences in IRT are non-significant ($\eta^2 < 1\,\%$). Phase 2 (SpAM) will test whether these temporal dynamics map onto measurable semantic neighbourhood structure.

10 References

References

[1] Troyer, A. K., Moscovitch, M., & Winocur, G. (1997). Clustering and switching as two components of verbal fluency: Evidence from younger and older healthy adults. *Neuropsychology*, *11*(1), 138–146.

[2] Hills, T. T., Jones, M. N., & Todd, P. M. (2012). Optimal foraging in semantic memory. *Psychological Review*, *119*(2), 431–440.

[3] Hout, M. C., Goldinger, S. D., & Ferguson, R. W. (2013). The versatility of SpAM. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: General*, *142*(1), 256–281.

[4] Benjamini, Y., & Hochberg, Y. (1995). Controlling the false discovery rate: A practical and powerful approach to multiple testing. *Journal of the Royal Statistical Society: Series B*, *57*(1), 289–300.

[5] Goldstone, R. (1994). An efficient method for obtaining similarity data. *Behavior Research Methods, Instruments, & Computers*, *26*(4), 381–386.

[6] Steyvers, M., & Tenenbaum, J. B. (2005). The large-scale structure of semantic networks. *Cognitive Science*, *29*(1), 41–78.

[7] Bhatt, R., Anderson, N. D., & Bhatt, M. (2022). Verbal fluency performance in bilingual South Asian older adults. *Journal of the International Neuropsychological Society*, *28*(4), 412–421.